The Lantern Hill Almanac

This almanac is invented test material for Loreland. Lantern Hill and everything described here are fictional.

Spring

Spring on Lantern Hill begins when the first swallow is seen over the signal tower. The station keepers record the date each year. The earliest swallow on record arrived on the ninth day of the Month of Thaw in the year 440.

Spring rain is light but frequent. The keepers expect rain on about two days in three. Farmers on the hill sow barley once the rain gauge has collected 8 thumbs of rain since the thaw, a custom the almanac calls the Eight Thumb Rule.

Late frosts are the main spring hazard. The almanac warns that a clear, still night after a warm day is the likeliest time for frost, and that a ring around the moon often comes one night before it.

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Summer

Summer on the hill is warm and mostly dry. The longest day of the year is marked by the Lantern Walk, when every household carries a lantern to the hilltop at dusk and leaves it burning until the evening bell.

Thunderstorms arrive from the west in the late afternoon. The almanac says that when the swifts fly low over the meadow, a storm will follow within three hours. The keepers have tested this saying for twenty summers and found it right about two times in three.

The hottest day in the record fell in the year 451, the same year as the great drought. The water in the stone trough beside the station dried up completely for the first and only time.

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Winter

Winter on Lantern Hill is cold but seldom snowy. Snow settles on the hilltop on about twelve days each winter, and on the village below on about five.

The keepers measure snow with a painted pole marked in hand widths. The deepest snow on record reached seven hand widths, in the Month of Ice in the year 443. The hill path was closed for sixteen days, and bread was carried up by sledge.

The almanac ends each winter with the Counting of Lanterns. On the last night of winter, the keepers count the lanterns lit in village windows and write the number in the record. The highest count so far is 131.